

SPLITSTREAM

DESIGN BRIEF & ARCHITECTURAL FRAMEWORK

Concept

A cooperative heist game for 1 to 4 players. Two teams rob the same location in two different eras simultaneously in a single session. *Example: a 2020 bank and a 2050 science lab on the same site.* Both maps run in real time for the entire session.

Teams & Mechanics

The Past Team physically acts within their timeline—stealing loot, hacking systems, picking locks, and neutralizing security guards.

The Future Team runs a full concurrent heist on their map but operates under a strict constraint: they cannot change history. Instead, they experience the structural and environmental consequences of the Past's actions in real time while pursuing their own objectives.

Neither team is passive. Both are structurally equal participants in the progression of the heist.

Communication

Asynchronous structural perspectives require constant synchronization. The Future team relays tactical intel to the Past team via voice chat, text chat, or tactical pings.

Strategic limitations prevent omnipotence: the Past cannot see the Future map layout or modifications, and the Future cannot physically interact with or affect the Past timeline directly.

The Loop

The core gameplay engine functions as a continuous, unpausing feedback mechanism between eras:

ASYNCHRONOUS FEEDBACK LOOP

Past Acts → Scores Shift → Future Map Reconfigures → Future Gathers Intel → Future Radios Past → Past Adapts

Operational Example: Future checks their archive computer terminal, which directs the Past team to hack *Computer 1*. As the Past team moves toward the target, they make micro-choices along the way—a guard is eliminated or a security camera is triggered. The underlying scores shift instantly. Future checks the archive again; the data has reconfigured, pointing now to *Computer 12*. Future radios the update to Past: "Reroute to Computer 12." Had the Past team maintained a perfectly clean insertion, the target infrastructure would not have shifted.

Goal & Economy

The shared objective requires players to collect a combined total value of **€50,000** pooled across both active timelines. Each map features independent, era-appropriate sources of value.

Any allocation of origin satisfies the victory condition (e.g., entirely from the Past, entirely from the Future, or an even split). There is no explicit session time limit.

Player Split Configurations

The engine scales dynamically across any player allocation layout:

2 - 2 3 - 1 1 - 3 4 - 0 0 - 4 1 Solo

If 100% of the player base occupies a single timeline (**4 - 0** or **0 - 4**), temporal interaction mechanics phase out, transitioning the session into a straight cooperative heist.

Loot Across Eras

Certain key objectives exist simultaneously across both timelines. An object or asset acquired in the Past map may scale exponentially in value when recovered in the Future map as a pristine historical artifact.

This introduces a critical cooperative decision point: secure the asset immediately for an immediate payout, or preserve and protect it through the timeline for a substantially larger yield in the future.

Score System & Causality Axes

The progression engine tracking the heist's escalation relies on four invisible metric axes fed exclusively by illegal or high-impact actions executed on the Past map. Players never view these scores as numeric values; instead, they observe the physical world shifting dynamically around them. Scores scale upward monotonically and are steered indirectly via playstyle choices.

PERSONNEL

Escalated by guard kills, body discoveries, and prolonged guard interactions. Alters guard density, routing, and aggressiveness in the Future timeline.

SECURITY

Driven by camera triggers, sloppy network hacks, and physical alarm interactions. Hardens digital grids and reconfigures automated defenses.

INFRASTRUCTURE

Raised via forced locks, severed cabling, and structural physical tampering. Results in blocked corridors, rerouted access paths, and facility layout changes in the Future.

STEALTH

Impacted by immediate visual detection, illegal area violations, and proximity alert tripping. Directly restricts the reliability and clarity of information the Future team can gather.

World Layers

The environments are systematically separated into two distinct operative layers:

- **Static Layer:** Fixed structural layouts and predictable cause-and-effect rules that players learn and master across multiple playthroughs.
- **Dynamic Layer:** The temporal loop implementation. This layer ensures every session diverges organically, as the entire Future map acts as a direct, fluid product of the Past team's performance.

Fail State

CRITICAL ALARM TRIGGERED: Tripping the ultimate facility alarm line immediately terminates the heist session. (Refer to existing core game documentation for complete operational details on the alarm mechanics).

Out of Scope for This Brief: Player progression architecture, character/team skill structures, and broader meta-game ecosystem loops are not yet finalized and are excluded from this documentation.